

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

THE ELECTION MANAGER

Assam chief minister **Himanta Biswa Sarma**'s behind-the-scenes skills were once again at work in the presidential and vice-presidential polls. In the July 18 presidential election, Sarma ensured that 22 Opposition MLAs—the highest from any state—cross-voted for NDA candidate Droupadi Murmu. More intriguing was his sudden, unscheduled meeting with rivals Jagdeep Dhankhar and Mamata Banerjee, one the former governor and the other the chief minister of West Bengal, in Darjeeling on July 13, four days before NDA announced Dhankhar as its VP pick. Later, Trinamool said it would abstain in the VP polls. And guess who Margaret Alva called after being declared UPA's VP nominee? Ex-Congressman Sarma, of course.

Freaky Friday



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In Parliament, private member bills are introduced only on Fridays. Except some of the most talked about private member bills have failed to see the light of day because those proposing them have gone missing on Fridays. BJP's **Kirodi Lal Meena** listed the Uniform Civil Code Bill in 2020. But it has not yet been taken up as the 70-year-old leader is never around on Fridays. Ditto with Places of Worship Bill, moved by BJP Rajya Sabha member Harnath Singh Yadav, 81. Most MPs skip Friday sessions to travel for weekend social functions. There has been a demand to shift private member bills to Wednesdays.

POLL BUGLE?

Is Jharkhand chief minister **Hemant Soren** preparing for a fresh election? Though assembly polls are still two years away, various units of his party, the JMM (Jharkhand Mukti Morcha), have been pushing the twitter trend #HemantnahitoKaun (who else but Hemant?), fuelling the speculation. With Soren already on the back foot with the Election Commission's disqualification notice over a mining lease and the Jharkhand High Court hearing the PIL against him, the JMM leader is perhaps thinking out of the box. The recent ouster of non-BJP CM Uddhav Thackeray in Maharashtra may have been another catalyst.



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–Kaushik Deka *with Jeemon Jacob, Amarnath K. Menon, Amitabh Srivastava and Romita Datta*



HERO TO ZERO

The appointment of **Sriram Venkitraman**, a 2012-batch IAS officer accused of drunken driving and killing a journalist in 2019, as the Alappuzha district collector has the Kerala Opposition and journalists up in arms. They have demanded a review of the appointment as the trial is yet to begin. Sriram, now 35, had been suspened for six months but later reinstated as a joint secretary in the health department. He now needs to complete two years of service in this post for his next promotion. A post-graduate in medicine, Sriram had become a youth icon when as Devikulam sub-collector, he had taken on the land mafia and illegal encroachments in Idukki. How the mighty have fallen.



Credit Score

Whatever the subject of their presser, Trinamool leaders never miss giving Chief Minister **Mamata Banerjee** credit for all the development work taking place in the state. Slowly but steadily, another name is being added to the list of acknowledgments—TMC general secretary and Mamata's nephew Abhishek Banerjee. The roles, though, are clearly defined. Mamata is hailed as the leader, and Abhishek the commander-in-chief.